Non-fiction

Fiction

Bookstore Inventory Analysis: Cost and Acquisitions

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How did this idea start?

2000/2001

Love of books fuels a dream and a vision to open a bookstore someday.

December 2025

I acquire a large donation of books left over from an estate sale.

January 2026

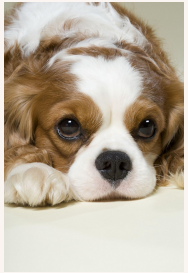
I mention bookstore vision to my wife, who loves the idea of starting a business.

February 2026

My bookselling and book collecting experience informs low-cost acquisition strategies.

March 2026

With over 500 books, I must now assess stock and plan future acquisitions.



Project Overview

01

Context

I have amassed a foundational inventory of 522 used books acquired through donations, thrift stores, and library sales.

02

Objectives

As part of my business plan, I seek to understand my inventory in terms of genre distribution, acquisition cost, and method of acquisition.

03

Outcomes

Insights will help me manage future acquisitions and costs, and achieve a more balanced inventory in a cost-efficient way.

Context & Caveats

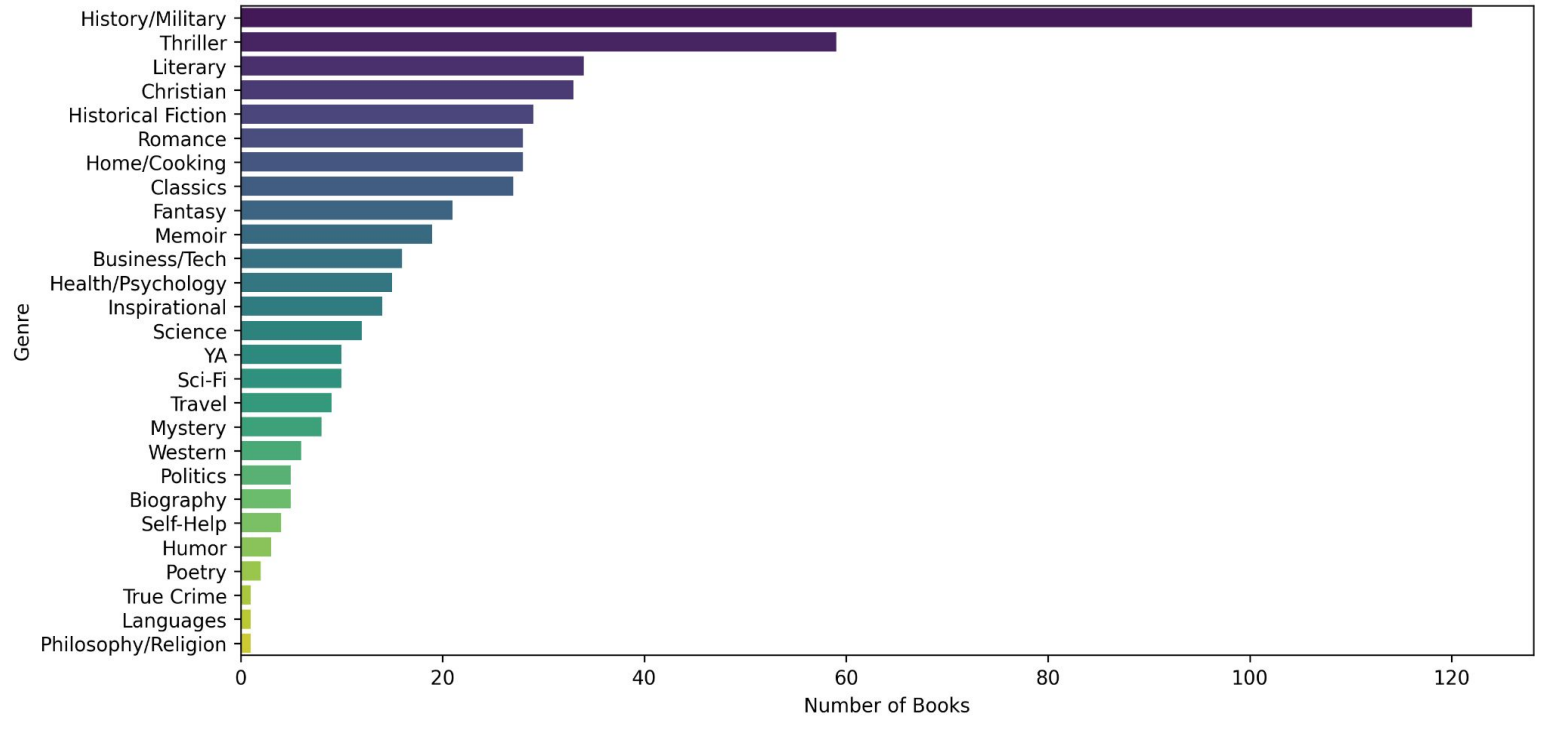
- **Total book count** is likely dependent on the size of the leased space.

- Acquisition costs reflect **bulk purchase averages**; format (hardcover vs. paperback) not assessed.

- Analysis is focused on **genres**, **acquisition costs**, and **acquisition methods** to identify opportunities for genre diversity and cost-efficiency.

- **No sales data yet**; still in inventory acquisition stage.

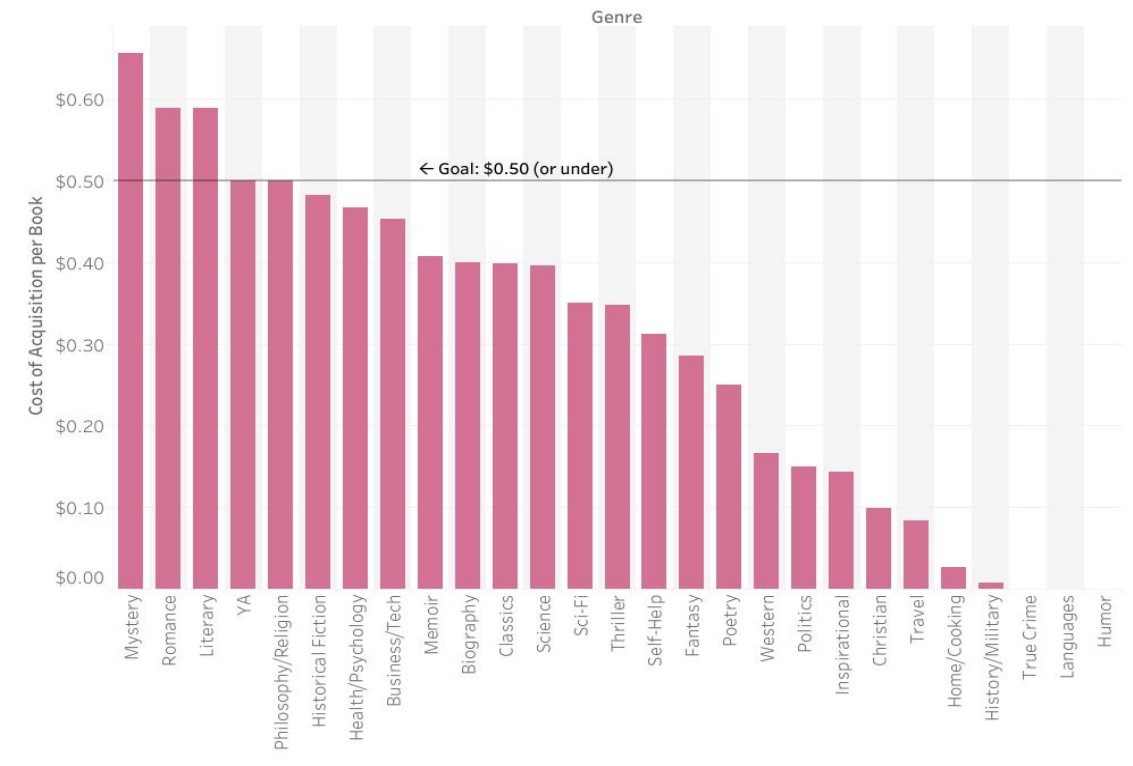
Number of Books per Genre



Assessment:

About a quarter of inventory so far is **history and military** books. While some genres are underrepresented, inventory standards vary by bookstore, location, and reader interest.

Acquisition Cost per Book (by Genre)



Target: $0.50 per book

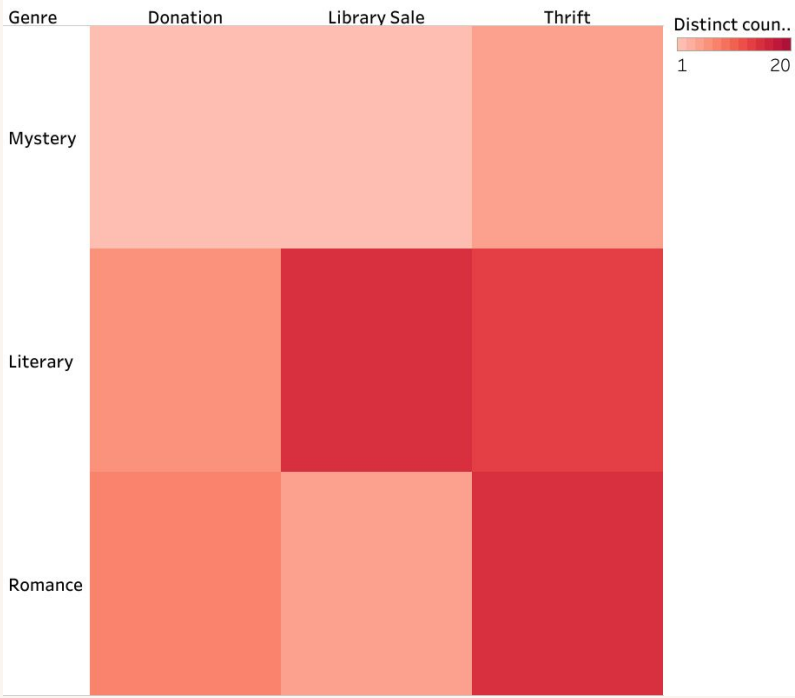
Mystery, **romance**, and **literary fiction** acquisitions exceeded this target.

History and military books, though abundant, were predominantly donated.

Key Takeaway:

Average acquisition cost per book overall is **$0.27**. Success spans many genres, not solely driven by donated history and military titles.

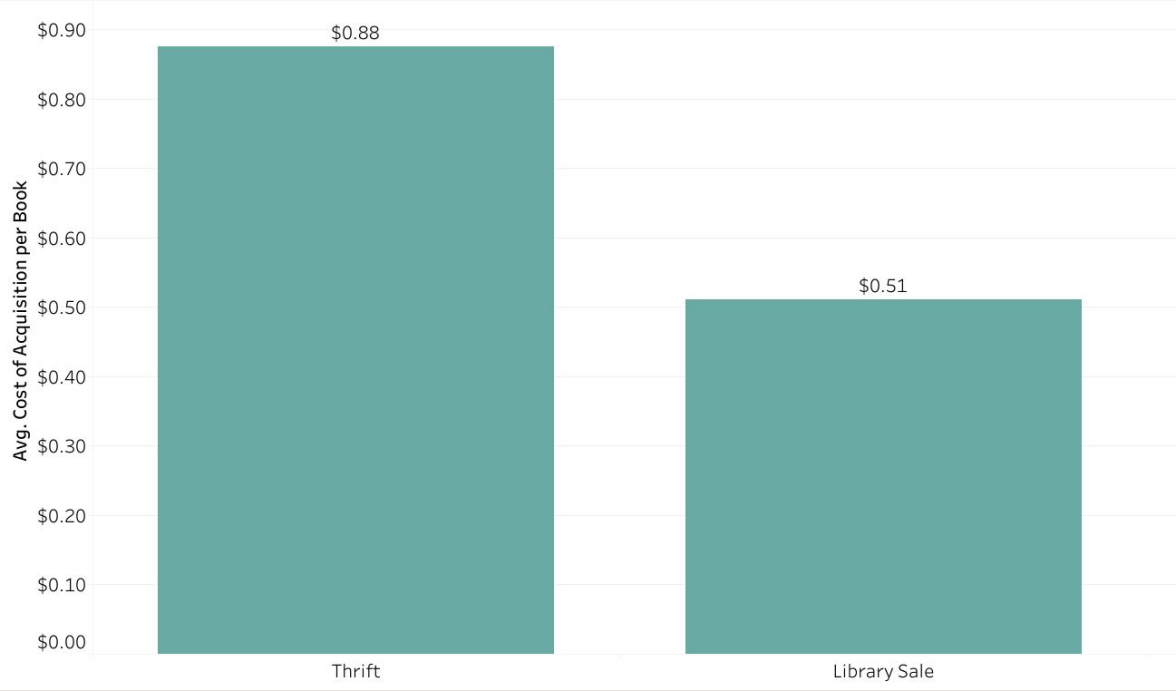
3 Priciest Genres on Average (Acquisition Method Breakdown)



Assessment:

Mystery, **romance**, and **literary fiction** have been heavily sourced through thrifting, though these genres can also be obtained through library sales or donations, offering multiple sourcing options.

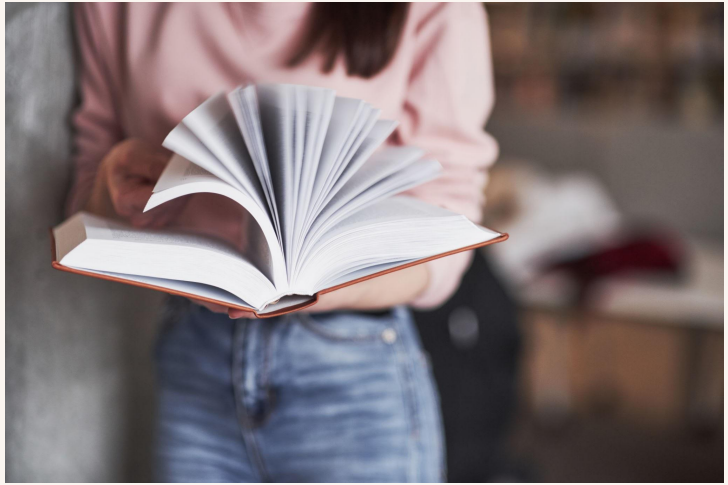
Average cost of Acquisitions per Book (by Method)



Thrifting far exceeded the $0.50 per book acquisition goal, while **library sales** were roughly on track.

**Donations not included due to acquisition cost being zero.

Conclusions



- Thrifting may fill gaps in underrepresented genres or high-margin titles, but **should not be the primary sourcing method for used books.**

- Continue leveraging **donations and library sales**, which provide cost-efficient acquisitions.

- Explore additional sourcing options, such as **yard sales, estate sales, online purchases**, or **direct from individuals.**

- **Consolidating some categories** (e.g. self-help with psychology) may **fill out emptier shelving** and **balance genre groups**.

- Current strategy is **robust to outlier donations**, suggesting scalability—efficient acquisitions remain possible even if donations shift.

Thank you!

Questions?

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